AJEET GIRI MAHARAJ

ALL DESIRE LOCKED AWAY

A small red-and-yellow tent. Inside, a naked figure sits cross-legged. The body is smeared in holy ash. The face, lit up by a flickering fire, looks no older than 25. But Ajeet Giri was that age in 2003, when he left his home in Kaushambi. In a decade, having done his own *pind-daan*—the funereal adieu to his past self—he was in the austere folds of the Naga order. Their transcendence is not only from their old worlds, but from all things corporeal. Ajeet symbolises that on his body. For seven years, he has lived with a 250-gram iron lock piercing his scrotum. "The pain took five or six months to go, now I do not even notice it," he says. "Naga sadhus follow various modes of *atal yoga*, I chose this."

